Chapter 13: Fight Back to Back. Take a Beating.

Four on four, Phyrn attacking Terrian, that was what had just been announced.

Rhys called to York, “Will you tell me how many will be in the battle against Aschelle, so I can choose my team?”

“No,” York responded. “I am sorry, but in war, there is no warning of what size of army is coming.”

“Not true,” Rhys countered. “That is what scouts are for.”

York stopped and stared at him, unsure what to say. He turned to Aschelle. “It is your choice. You may not give any information, or we can decide if this is to be six against six or one on one.”

One on one… That sounded awful. Rhys was about to fight. How could he go into a one on one battle for his life with his gem not full after that?

There was actually some relief when Aiden the

Invincible announced, “We will fight six on six.”

There were murmurs through the crowd. Six on six was not often done. Then again, if Aschelle won, Rhys would be turned over to them, and likely tortured and killed.

Rhys saw that Phyrn was coming on the field with Slayde, Grunth, Gorn, and Draxie. Draxie and Bantha were the two female war mages on Phyrn’s team, and both were large and strong. Draxie fought with a sword.

Rhys noticed none of them used distance weapons. He could send in a bowman to try to pick them off from a distance, but he might need Cedric against Aschelle, as they could send distance fighters easily.

“Ronan, Blake, Eoin, you’re with me,” Rhys called to his team. “Let’s win this.”

As Ronan stepped up, he assured Rhys, “You aren’t going down if I can help it.”

“Same here,” Blake added.

The four of them took the field.

“Prepare to die!” Slayde hissed as his team stood facing off with Terrian.

“It’s to gems dark,” Rhys pointed out.

Slayde turned and called to York, “This fight is to retrieve Bruis. May my side only fight after our gems go dark? It could mean Bruis’s life.”

York thought for a moment and decided, “I do not

think Bruis's life is in danger, as he's spent weeks captured and is alive, but I will grant your request."

That wasn't something Rhys wanted to hear. With Phyrn fighting past gems dark, he was going to take a beating, and he likely wasn't going to win without killing Slayde. He had never killed a man and never wanted to.

Yet, the rules were not arguable, so he stood his ground ready to fight.

York called for the battle to begin. Phyrn came out strong, and all against Rhys, but Blake, Ronan, and Eoin stepped in front of him and started fighting.

The battle was brutal. Phyrnians were big, strong, and fierce.

The first gem to go dark was Krunt's, but he did not leave the field.

Blake's went dark next, and he had no choice but to leave the field and leave his teammates outnumbered.

Rhys wished he'd brought in Cedric with his bow, but at the time he called for the team, he didn't know Phyrn was going to be able to fight past gems dark.

He didn't get to debate his choice because he was in the middle of a fight. Phyrn was obviously not just trying to win and get Bruis back; they were out for blood.

The fight became very ugly as more of the Terrian team had their gems go dark. Gorn was the only one from Phyrn who left the field, and that was because he was too wounded to fight and was carried off.

When the fight came down to only Rhys left against Slayde, Grunth, and Draxie, Rhys knew he couldn't win. There was no way he could beat all three of the Phyrnians, even though he'd badly cut Slayde and Draxie was obviously light-headed. All three would fight to the death, and he would die.

"I concede the fight!" Rhys called to York, seeing his gem was about to go dark.

"Stop!" York called to the fighters. The Phyrnians did stop fighting. With as much as they would have loved to have killed Rhys, they knew not to keep fighting when told to stop. That would be punished.

York announced, "Terrian has lost. You will return Bruis to Phyrn."

Rhys nodded and started to walk off the field. As he did, Slayde struck at him discreetly. His gem went dark and he started to bleed. Rhys put his hand in the wound to try to stop the bleeding and called up to York, "My gem is dark. May I have others fight the next battle?"

"No," York answered. "Team captains must fight."

"But Slayde was…" Rhys started to argue.

"Enough!" York scolded. "I have made my decision. Question it and get punished."

Rhys became suddenly quieter and asked, "May I be healed? You allowed it for Slayde."

"But you fight now," York answered. "There is not time."

“I need to get my team,” Rhys called back. “And you took the time to heal...”

“Enough!” York countered. “You may heal enough to be eligible to fight. Call your team down.”

Something was really odd. Rhys really didn’t know York well. He’d been the counselor for Aschelle before taking Carlin’s place, but that’s all Rhys knew of him… and that the Terrian counselor didn’t care much for him. Why didn’t York want Rhys healed? Was there a reason that York wanted him captured or dead? Obviously, he favored Aschelle, as he was from there. Carlin had also been from Aschelle, but he at least tried to look unbiased.

Rhys didn’t get the chance to call for his team. Hrod, Sean, Flynn, Catria, and Cedric started down before he called for anyone.

Rhys watched them come. That’s who he’d have called, except he’d have called for Jareth, not Catria. She was new and Aschelle was going to be a tough fight.

“You don’t have to come,” Rhys told Catria. “You need to heal me. Then you can go back to the platform or stay in one of the alcoves over there.” He pointed to boxes built into the sides of the arena where teams could go if they were injured or watch their teammates fight from.

“I insist,” Catria explained. “I am healing you, and I’m fighting beside you.”

She did start healing him. As soon as York saw some glow from Rhys’s gem, he called out, “This is for Rhys’s

life. Thus, he can fight past his gem going dark."

"Let the entire team," Hrod called up. "You let all of Phyrn, so it's only fair."

"Granted," York approved. "Begin."

Hrod had expected some debate, but apparently York wanted the battle to start quickly and Rhys not be fully healed. Likely, York was going to be worse about cheating for Aschelle than Carlin was.

"Leave if you need to," Rhys called to his team as Aschelle charged at them. "Don't die protecting me."

For a moment, Catria could hardly breathe. She'd practice fighting, but now, she had Freya Flashdaggers charging at her with her knives on chains. Freya was good. She hadn't been on the team long, but she had trained all her life to be a war mage, and Quex the Unstoppable, who'd been on the team for a few years, was courting her and working with her. Both were nasty fighters, the type who always tried to draw blood when they took down their opponent.

Catria held her staff ready, not quite sure how to fight a keyoketsu shogi, Freya's weapon.

The knife and chain whipped around her staff, and Freya tried to pull Catria's staff from her. Fortunately, Catria was stronger than Freya.

Catria kicked Freya back and tried to untangle the weapons but Freya's knife struck her as she did. Catria was very glad for shielding.

She continued to fight, very aware of the fight around her. Freya struck hard, but not as hard as Aiden, Quex, Camdor, or Tyrus. The men were in a horrible fight. It was so much more brutal to see from the field than from the stands.

Lorelay from Aschelle was the first to leave the match as her gem went dark. As she walked off the field, she took a subtle strike, stabbing Catria with her battle fan.

Catria had been warned that sometimes that happened, generally by war mages from Aschelle or Phyrn. Still, it was different being on the receiving end.

Catria's shield held, so the extra hit didn't hurt her. Still, it was one less hit she'd be able to take in the fight, and even with shielding, the hits hurt. The gems protected from damage, but not from all the pain.

The first war mage on her team to have his gem go dark was Flynn, and when his shielding went down, he received a bad cut to his side. Yet, he tried to continue fighting.

"Get off the field," Rhys called to him.

"No," Catria called back. "Help me!"

Hrod was fighting near her, so he kicked Quex back and struck at Freya to draw her off Catria.

Fighting Quex and Freya sounded deadly for Hrod, so Catria knew she had to hurry. She ran over to Flynn and put her hand on his wound. There wasn't time to fully heal, but it instantly closed over and his gem started

glowing faintly.

“I’m good,” Flynn assured her before he charged over to help Hrod with Quex and Freya.

He jumped between Freya and Hrod and struck the blow that took Freya’s shielding down. She threw a knife at him and pulled it back by the chain before leaving the field.

That left three on six, as Tyrus had just been put out by Sean.

Three on six was a sure loss for the three, so Aiden, Quex, and Camdor all charged, but not at Rhys as would have been expected, at Catria.

She parried a blow from Quex’s large war hammer to find she didn’t have the strength to stop it. As she parried there, Aiden cut with his sword. It didn’t just cut, but she felt herself shake all over, as if she’d been struck by lightning.

Hrod, Rhys and the others jumped in quickly to protect her, so Camdor didn’t strike her with his trident.

Still, she fell to the ground in a pool of blood, her gem dark, and her world spinning, but she couldn’t pass out. She had to heal.

A sudden flash of white light came from her, and her eyes opened and she rolled to her hands and knees. Her wound starting to heal already.

Everyone stared at her for a moment, the light catching their attention. Then, the battle started full again

with Aiden, Quex, and Camdor all attacking Rhys.

Of course the rest of Team Terrian did come to Rhys's aid, but his shielding had gone down long before, so a strike from Aiden's lightning sword brought him down. Quex then hit him with his war hammer.

Rhys fell, and the crowd suddenly went silent in horror, wondering if Rhys had died.

"Help Rhys!" Hrod called to Catria as he charged in to fight.

Catria wasn't healed enough to walk, but she crawled over to Rhys.

Sean and Flynn charged in, but Cedric didn't. He hid behind a tree and shot arrows. His first one took Camdor's shielding down, forcing him to leave the field.

Aiden shot lightning from his sword and brought Cedric's shielding down. Cedric did not stop fighting, but did take better cover behind trees. He let an arrow fly, hitting Aiden, almost bringing his shielding down.

Hrod followed the shot up by striking the final blow, and Quex's gem went dark. He swore at Hrod and tried a subtle strike before leaving the field, but Hrod was expecting it and blocked.

That left Aiden against the entire Terrian team. Sure the team was wounded and not fighting their best, but he still didn't have much chance.

Yet, a smile crossed his face as he blasted lightning at Catria and Rhys. Sean tried to interpose himself by

jumping in the way, but where he was shocked, he didn't stop either Rhys or Catria from getting blasted.

Catria's gem again went dark and some of the lightning got through. Both she and Rhys screamed in pain. She turned to see Rhys with Aiden's lightning sword through his chest.

Catria forced herself up and ran over to heal Rhys, hoping she could make it before he died. She had strong healing, but couldn't heal from death.

The other four of Terrian's team saw her going to heal Rhys and all ganged up on Aiden. Very quickly, his gem went dark. Terrian had won.

Catria focused on healing Rhys. It was hard since she wasn't healed herself yet, but she had to keep him alive. He couldn't die.

York announced Terrian's win and then declared, "The captain of Aschelle's team will now be punished due to attacking and failing."

The crowd gasped. None of them wanted to see more blood… None, but Ramere. They cheered for the punishment, chanting, "We want blood!"

Catria shook her head. How could they see such bloody battles as a game?

York quieted the crowd and continued, "Before the punishment, the wounded must be tended to. Is Rhys alive?"

"Yes," Hrod called up to York, as Catria was too

focused on healing to answer. “At least, I think so.”

Catria kept her hands on Rhys and glowed, but her light was fainter than usual due to her own wounds.

York again addressed the crowd. “We’ve had a fatal wound that was only survived due to Catria’s healing. There are no more battles. Everyone is dismissed.”

Had Aschelle just avoided the punishment of attacking and losing? Perhaps York was playing favorites.

Ramere began to chant for the punishment, but York quieted them, insisting he’d already dismissed everyone and they were to disperse. No one argued. Arguing could be punished.

As Team Terrian started to leave, with Hrod and Sean helping Rhys walk, Erik and the rest of Team Cruia ran up to them. Erik offered Catria, “May I carry you? You look weak. Save your energy for healing.”

She agreed, so he picked her up. Catria was not small and frail. She was a little taller than average for a girl, and very strong, but Erik picked her up easily. After all, he did have war mage strength.

He carried her all the way to the complex and to the Terrian wing, where both teams gathered in a room.

“This was an eventful day,” Rhys noted. He then turned to Dillion and suggested, “Our teams should talk.”

“They should,” Dillion agreed.

Erik then whispered to Catria. “We should talk too. This is important.”

Chapter 14: Propose. Get Feared.

Rhys was taken to the complex and put in bed. The rest of team Terrian and team Cruia came with him. Catria did more healing of him, but with as near death as he was and as weak as Catria was, he wouldn't be up soon."

"I'm done," Rhys announced. "I want to retire."

"You'll be recovered and up to fighting again soon," Hrod assured him.

"No," Rhys corrected. "I was honestly debating retiring anyway. I have been captain a long time, and I'm tired of fighting. I want you to be the next captain, Hrod."

"You can't retire," Hrod countered. "We don't have a war mage to replace you. You can't retire until the next soul quest."

"I can replace him," Erik offered. "I don't want to be captain, as I'm new, but I can transfer to Team Terrian." He looked over at Dillion. "You'd approve that, wouldn't